

SLOW COOKER & INSTANT POT

Cozy Crockpot Dinners

5 easy dump-and-go dinners for busy weeks, with 2 cozy recipes from Georgia, where my family lives.



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How to use this guide

Slow cooker (Crockpot)

Low and slow. Put everything in before work and come home to dinner. LOW is gentler, HIGH is about twice as fast.

Instant Pot / pressure cooker

Fast. "Natural release" means you leave the valve closed and let the pressure drop on its own.

My 5 golden rules

1

Fill it halfway to two-thirds.

Too empty and food dries out, too full and it won't cook evenly.

2

Don't lift the lid.

Every peek in a slow cooker adds about 15–20 minutes to the cooking time.

3

Dairy goes in at the end.

Cream, cheese and milk can split if they cook for hours. Stir them in during the last 15–30 minutes.

4

Tomatoes on top in the Instant Pot.

Thick sauces on the bottom can trigger the burn warning. Layer them on top and don't stir before cooking.

5

Herbs and garlic last.

Fresh herbs and a little raw garlic at the end make every stew taste brighter.

Good to know

Cooking times are a guide and can vary depending on your appliance and the size of your pieces.

Chicken is safe to eat at 74 °C (165 °F). Most dishes keep 3–4 days in the fridge or up to 3 months in the freezer (except the creamy ones).



RECIPE 1 OF 5

Salsa Pulled Chicken

3 ingredients · tacos, bowls & wraps

Serves 6

Prep 5 min

 Slow cooker **LOW 6 h · HIGH 3–4 h**

 Instant Pot **12 min + 10 min release**

Gluten-free

Ingredients

- ☐ 900 g (2 lb) chicken breasts or thighs
- ☐ 1 jar salsa (450 g / 16 oz)
- ☐ 1 tbsp taco seasoning
- ☐ Juice of 1 lime
- ☐ Salt to taste



Slow cooker

LOW 6 h · HIGH 3–4 h

- 1 Put the chicken in the pot and sprinkle with taco seasoning.
- 2 Pour the salsa over the top.
- 3 Cook until the chicken shreds easily.
- 4 Shred with two forks, stir in the lime juice and taste for salt.



Instant Pot

12 min + 10 min release

- 1 Add ½ cup (120 ml) water to the pot, then the chicken and seasoning.
- 2 Pour the salsa on top. **Don't stir**, so you won't get a burn warning.
- 3 Pressure cook on HIGH for 12 min, then let the pressure release naturally for 10 min.
- 4 Shred, add the lime juice and stir.

Serve it with

Warm tortillas, rice bowls with corn and avocado, or nachos with melted cheese.

Leftovers

Keeps 4 days in the fridge. Roll it into a wrap with rice and cheese for tomorrow's lunch.

MY NOTES



RECIPE 2 OF 5

Creamy Tuscan Chicken

sun-dried tomatoes · spinach · parmesan

Serves 4

Prep 10 min



Slow cooker LOW 4–5 h · HIGH 2–3 h

⚡ Instant Pot 10 min + 5 min release

Gluten-free

Ingredients

- ☐ 700 g (1½ lb) chicken breasts
- ☐ 1 cup (240 ml) chicken broth
- ☐ 4 garlic cloves, minced
- ☐ ½ cup sun-dried tomatoes, chopped
- ☐ 1 tsp Italian seasoning · salt & pepper
- ☐ *To finish:* 1 cup (240 ml) heavy cream
- ☐ ½ cup grated parmesan
- ☐ 2 big handfuls of spinach



Slow cooker

LOW 4–5 h · HIGH 2–3 h

- 1 Season the chicken and place it in the pot.
- 2 Add the broth, garlic, sun-dried tomatoes and Italian seasoning.
- 3 Cook until tender. Chicken breasts dry out, so don't cook longer!
- 4 Stir in the cream, parmesan and spinach. Cover for 15 min until the spinach wilts.



Instant Pot

10 min + 5 min release

- 1 Add the broth, then the chicken, garlic, tomatoes and seasoning.
- 2 Pressure cook on HIGH for 10 min, then natural release for 5 min.
- 3 Take out the chicken. Switch to **Sauté**.
- 4 Stir in the cream, parmesan and spinach and simmer 2–3 min. Return the chicken.

Serve it with

Pasta, rice or mashed potatoes, and crusty bread for the sauce.

Leftovers

Keeps 3 days in the fridge. Slice the chicken and toss it with pasta and the sauce.

MY NOTES



RECIPE 3 OF 5

Chicken Pot Pie Soup

all the comfort, none of the pastry work

Serves 6

Prep 15 min

 Slow cooker LOW 6–7 h · HIGH 3–4 h

 Instant Pot 10 min + 10 min release

Ingredients

- ☐ 500 g (1 lb) chicken breasts
- ☐ 1 onion, chopped
- ☐ 3 carrots, sliced
- ☐ 2 celery stalks, sliced
- ☐ 2 potatoes, cubed
- ☐ 2 garlic cloves, minced
- ☐ 4 cups (1 l) chicken broth
- ☐ 1 tsp dried thyme · salt & pepper
- ☐ *To finish:* 1 cup (240 ml) milk or cream
- ☐ 3 tbsp flour
- ☐ 1 cup frozen peas



Slow cooker

LOW 6–7 h · HIGH 3–4 h

- 1 Put the chicken, vegetables, garlic, broth and thyme in the pot.
- 2 Cook until the vegetables are soft.
- 3 Take out the chicken, shred it and put it back.
- 4 Whisk the flour into the milk, stir it in with the peas. Cook 20–30 min more on HIGH until thick.



Instant Pot

10 min + 10 min release

- 1 Add everything except the milk, flour and peas.
- 2 Pressure cook on HIGH for 10 min, then natural release for 10 min.
- 3 Shred the chicken. Switch to **Sauté**.
- 4 Whisk the flour into the milk, stir it in with the peas and simmer 3–5 min until thick.

Serve it with

Puff pastry squares baked until golden, biscuits or a slice of bread.

Leftovers

Keeps 4 days in the fridge. It thickens overnight, so add a splash of broth when reheating.

MY NOTES



RECIPE 4 OF 5

Ajapsandali

Georgian vegetable stew

Serves 4–6

Prep 20 min



Slow cooker LOW 6–7 h · HIGH 3–4 h

⚡ Instant Pot 6 min + 10 min release

Vegan

Ingredients

- ☐ 2 eggplants, cubed
- ☐ 3 potatoes, cubed
- ☐ 2 carrots, sliced
- ☐ 2 bell peppers (red + green), chopped
- ☐ 2 onions, chopped
- ☐ 4 tomatoes, chopped (or 1 can, 400 g)
- ☐ 2 tbsp tomato paste
- ☐ 5 garlic cloves, minced
- ☐ 1 small chili (optional)
- ☐ 1 tsp ground coriander · 2 bay leaves · salt
- ☐ 4 tbsp oil
- ☐ *To finish:* fresh cilantro, basil & parsley



Slow cooker

LOW 6–7 h · HIGH 3–4 h

- 1 Fry the eggplant, onions and peppers in the oil for 5–7 min until golden. This gives the stew its flavor.
- 2 Put them in the pot with the potatoes, carrots, spices and chili.
- 3 Add the tomatoes and tomato paste on top.
- 4 Cook until everything is soft. Stir in the garlic and herbs before serving.



Instant Pot

6 min + 10 min release

- 1 On **Sauté**, fry the eggplant, onions and peppers in the oil for 5–7 min.
- 2 Add the potatoes, carrots, spices and ½ cup (120 ml) water.
- 3 Add the tomatoes and paste **on top, don't stir**.
- 4 Pressure cook on HIGH for 6 min, natural release 10 min. Stir in the garlic and herbs.

Serve it with

Fresh bread and a piece of salty cheese. In Georgia it's often eaten warm or at room temperature.

Leftovers

Tastes even better the next day! Keeps 4 days in the fridge.

MY NOTES



RECIPE 5 OF 5

Lobio

Georgian bean stew

Serves 4–6

Prep 10 min

 Slow cooker LOW 6–8 h · HIGH 4 h

 Instant Pot 30 min + 15 min release

Vegan

Ingredients

- ☐ 400 g (2 cups) dried red kidney beans, soaked overnight
- ☐ 1 onion, finely chopped
- ☐ 4 garlic cloves, minced
- ☐ 1 tbsp tomato paste
- ☐ 1 tsp ground coriander
- ☐ ½ tsp blue fenugreek (utskho suneli), optional
- ☐ ½ tsp chili flakes · 1 bay leaf · salt
- ☐ 1 tbsp oil
- ☐ *To finish:* ½ cup crushed walnuts (optional), fresh cilantro

Slow cooker

LOW 6–8 h · HIGH 4 h

- 1 **Important:** boil the soaked beans hard in a regular pot for 10 min first. Red kidney beans aren't safe if cooked only at low heat.
- 2 Drain and put them in the slow cooker with the onion, spices, tomato paste and oil.
- 3 Cover with water by 3 cm (1 inch) and cook until very soft.
- 4 Mash about a third of the beans. Stir in the garlic, walnuts and cilantro. Season with salt.

Instant Pot

30 min + 15 min release

- 1 Drain the soaked beans and add them with the onion, spices, tomato paste and oil.
- 2 Cover with water by 3 cm (1 inch).
- 3 Pressure cook on HIGH for 30 min, then natural release for 15 min.
- 4 Mash a third of the beans, then stir in the garlic, walnuts, cilantro and salt.

Serve it with

Cornbread, pickles and a fresh tomato & cucumber salad.

Leftovers

Short on time? Use 3 cans of beans (drained): slow cooker 3–4 h on LOW or Instant Pot 5 min.

MY NOTES

Shopping list

Meat

- ☐ Chicken breasts or thighs · 2.1 kg (4½ lb) total

Vegetables & herbs

- ☐ Onions · 4
- ☐ Garlic · 2 heads
- ☐ Carrots · 5
- ☐ Potatoes · 5
- ☐ Eggplants · 2
- ☐ Bell peppers · 2
- ☐ Tomatoes · 4
- ☐ Celery · 2 stalks
- ☐ Spinach · 2 big handfuls
- ☐ Small chili · 1 (optional)
- ☐ Fresh cilantro, basil & parsley
- ☐ Lime · 1

Pantry

- ☐ Salsa · 1 jar (450 g / 16 oz)
- ☐ Sun-dried tomatoes · ½ cup
- ☐ Tomato paste · 1 small can
- ☐ Chicken broth · 5 cups (1.25 l)
- ☐ Dried red kidney beans · 400 g (or 3 cans)
- ☐ Flour · 3 tbsp
- ☐ Walnuts · ½ cup (optional)
- ☐ Oil

Dairy & frozen

- ☐ Heavy cream · 1 cup
- ☐ Milk or cream · 1 cup
- ☐ Parmesan · ½ cup grated
- ☐ Frozen peas · 1 cup

Spices

- ☐ Taco seasoning
- ☐ Italian seasoning
- ☐ Dried thyme
- ☐ Ground coriander
- ☐ Blue fenugreek (optional)
- ☐ Chili flakes · bay leaves
- ☐ Salt & pepper



30-minute Sunday prep

1. Soak the kidney beans overnight.
2. Chop all the onions and mince the garlic.
3. Slice the carrots, celery and peppers.
4. Cube the eggplant and potatoes on cooking day (they brown).
5. Pack each recipe's veggies in its own labeled box or bag.
6. On cooking day: open, dump, switch on. Done!

